Time Share

By Neil LaBute

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: The facts about marital infidelity are astounding. Polls show that although 90% of married people disapprove of extramarital relationships, statistics from a national survey indicate that 15% of wives and 25% of husbands have experienced an extramarital affair.

ACTOR: Another source, The Monogamy Myth, authored by Peggy Vaughan, approximates that 60% of husbands and 40% of wives will have an affair at some time in their marriage.

ACTRESS: Every day in America, seemingly happily married couples face the very real aftermath that the discovery of marital infidelity can bring to a relationship.

ACTOR: Rationalizations, explanations, grief, anger – Marriage is not the appropriate relationship to propose a . . .

TOGETHER: Time Share by Neil LaBute

SHE: Say that again.

HE: What, about before?

SHE: Yes, that. Please.

HE: Well, see, we, ummm . . . . the two of us had actually met before.

SHE: Before?

HE: I mean, before we met. From before we, that is you and I, knew one another.

SHE: Really?

HE: Yeah. We went to the same college and . . .

SHE: Oh. So ... you were in school together?

HE: No, no, not *together*. It was in Kansas, but not overlapping or anything. No, we actually ran into each other in the city one time, during this coed softball game of alumni in Central Park.

SHE: Quaint.

HE: Which is kind of funny . . .

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SHE: Why? Why is that funny?

HE: Well, it's, you know . . . Manhattan. And that's where we went to school, too. Manhattan, I mean. In Kansas. Because Kansas State is in. . .

SHE: Yeah, Manhattan. I get it. It's just not that funny.

HE: Right. Anyway, that's where we were, over by the softball fields, and, see, we got talking about stuff, had a couple drinks, you know, and we just hung out a few times or whatever.

SHE: I think they still call it 'dating,' even in New York.

HE: No it wasn't like a *'thing'*! We didn't date or anything, we just . . .

SHE: Slept together.

HE: . . . something like that. Yeah, this one time we did, yes. Do that, I mean. Not *sleeping* together, though, just some sex stuff. Sort of. But it was nothing . . .

SHE: So that makes it all right, then . . . what I saw.

HE: No, not all right, I'm not saying that, I just mean . . . I dunno, just that there's some background there. A shared background between us.

SHE: Right. I see. I get it. I do. I do get it.

HE: So, it's not like, I mean ... a 'fling' or anything.

SHE: It isn't?

HE: Well, OK, yes, a fling, but ... a fling with qualifiers. With *history*.

SHE: You didn't tell me, though. About this 'history' of yours, I mean. All this time and you didn't say anything.

HE: No, I didn't do that.

SHE: Why?

HE: I thought that I wouldn't, you know . . .

SHE: Uh-uh, no, I don't know. What? Get caught?

HE: No. B-b-be understood.

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SHE: Well, you're right, you wouldn't b-b-be, but that shouldn't stop you from telling me!"

HE: What was I gonna say?

SHE: I don't know, it's not really my moral dilemma, is it?

HE: It's not a . . . OK, yeah, it is, like, a *moral* thing, but I think we can still . . . "

SHE: Still what? What? I'd love to hear how that sentence ends. Tell me.

HE: . . . work something out? Or . .

SHE: You think we should work it out, do you? Is that what you think?

HE: I think we could try.

SHE: Try what, talking? Just, like, *talking*, you and me?

HE: We could, yes. That would be . . . If we can't talk about this like adults, then we might as, well . . .

SHE: Adults? Oh, you wanna talk like *ad*-ults, is that what you'd like?

HE: It's why I came back over here, yes.

SHE: No, you came back over because this is your house, OK, this is your *home*. Where you live! What'd you think, you could just live in the pool house there, set up a little place for yourselves or something?

HE: No. Of course not. Look, I don't know what you think you saw . . .

SHE: Oh, please, come on . . .

HE: No, seriously, what? We weren't . . .

SHE: Your trunks were down, all right?

HE: They weren't . . . OK, whatever. You know what you know.

SHE: No, not whatever. I saw you, very clearly, your suit around your knees. Your back was toward the door and. . . do you really wanna hear more?

HE: . . no. But . . .we knew each other in New York . . .

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SHE: What does that mean?! You keep saying that but it doesn't seem to mean anything. *Lots* of people know each other in the city, but that doesn't mean they're all doing it. Does it?

HE: No, but, see . . .we went to the same college and we got talking one time, we had a lot to drink and we just . . . it wasn't like this big thing.

SHE: But you didn't tell me.

HE: No.

SHE: They've been moved in there, next door, in their time-share for three weeks. A month maybe. Since Memorial Day . . .

HE: I was going to say something . . .

SHE: But you decided to keep it all to yourself, huh?

HE: No! God, you're so . . .we were both nervous about it. I mean, embarrassed.

SHE: Obviously . . .

HE: We were! When they introduced themselves that first day, out there on the deck, I could hardly look up . . . Jesus, let me at least tell my side of it.

SHE: Please . . . go ahead.

HE: So, you know . . .if you don't take that moment, I mean, that first moment there and tell the truth, then you're stuck. You are.

SHE: And since you didn't tell me out on the porch that day, you just figured this tiny detail was no big thing. I mean, not a real problem for us . . .is that kind of what you're saying?

HE: Sort of . . .

SHE: Huh.

HE: What's that mean?

SHE: Just 'huh,' no other real meaning to it . . ." [Her head cocks a touch now, slightly to one side as she studies him. Glancing at his eyes but then down, to settle at crotch

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level. Holding this look for quite some time. He shifts from one bare foot to the other.]

HE: What're you doing?

SHE: Nothing. Just imagining . . .

HE: Imagining?

SHE: Imagining what it'd be like for your son to walk into that shed. Looking for, oh, I dunno, some diving sticks or an *inner tube* or who knows what, and see that. What I saw . . .

HE: What? We knew each other in Manhattan . . .

SHE: Stop saying *that*!

HE: We were just talking . . .

SHE: Please don't do that! Don't assume I've been nearsighted all these years on top of being an idiot . . . Would you like it, if he saw that?"

HE: No. Of course not. . .

SHE: Well, that's something . . . Because I couldn't really see . . .my eyes hadn't adjusted. I was pretty sure that's what was happening there, with the two of you, but I wasn't completely. Certain, I mean. Because of the dark. But, hey, now I know . . .

HE: Listen, we were just . . .

SHE: Right. Yeah, college, I know . . . The big game and all.

HE: Yep . . . I mean, you're in the city, right? And you run into a bunch of folks from home, you know, men and women out there on the grass having fun, and you just sort of get caught up in the thing . . .few beers . . .I can't really explain it better than that . . .Does that make any sense?

SHE: No, none. But I understand. I understand that it makes sense to you . . . somehow.

HE: It does. I know it sounds wobbly, but . . .S

HE: And since it does, make sense, I mean, you'll need to explain it to them . . .

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HE: Who?

SHE: The children.

HE: . . what do you mean?

SHE: You're going to need to sit them down—they're back from swimming in forty minutes—and you'll need to walk them through this as best you can.

HE: No, I can't . . .what?

SHE: My leaving, I mean. You'll need to come up with something for that. Tell them the rest if you want to, but you have to explain where I've gone.

HE: But where are you . . .?

SHE: To the city, I suppose. For the night, anyway. I need to call my sister, and the lawyers, no doubt. I need to handle a few things.

HE: I can't tell them that! I mean, they're only . . .

SHE: What, children?

HE: Yes.

SHE: Children bounce back. They do, that's their lot in life. You explain things and on Saturday we'll get them on a train, back into town, and they'll be out of your hair. Then you can go back over the fence . . .

HE: But I don't want to.

SHE: Then don't.

HE: I want to . . .I mean, I'd like to, I'd really like to see if we could . . .

SHE: What? [She waits for him to finish but he only repeats the previous phrases over and over. Finally, she picks up her bag, tests the weight of it, then moves toward the door.]

HE: Do you want me to carry that down or . . .?

SHE: No, no, it's fine. You've done enough, believe me . . .

HE: I love you guys. I do.

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SHE: Well, that's something you can hang on to, isn't it? You can tell the kids that, if it helps . . .tell them I love them, too.

HE: We were just talking . . .we spent time on the same *campus*, for Chrissakes!

SHE Yeah, I caught that part . . .

HE: We did . . .

SHE: I know.

HE: And we had some . . .

SHE: When did you become so pathetic?

HE: . . . I'm not sure.

SHE: Huh.Tell me one thing . . .

HE: Yes?

SHE: What position did he play?

HE: Huh?

SHE: Our *neighbor* . . .the guy who was . . . When you met him, what position was he playing?

HE: Oh . . . catcher. He was their catcher.

SHE: . . . I see. I get it now . . .The significance of it all.

HE: What do you mean?

SHE: Come on, he's the *catcher* . . .you don't know anyone, you're lonely, it's New York, this guy's kneeling at your feet, you've got your nice, firm bat there . . . I get it. It's *symbolic* . .

HE: It . . .it was an experiment, that's all. Just . . . guy stuff. Kind of, like, you know . . .

SHE: No, you're right. It happens. It does. In 'Manhattan,' anyway . .

HE: We were only . . .see, I met him before we, I mean, you and me . . .

SHE: . . . I hope you're very happy." [Before he can say anything else she is gone]

HE: [Alone on stage] It's OK, it is, it's OK, this is gonna be . . .it's all right. Things'll be fine. It's . . . OK, this is all O-K . . ."

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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